

LISTENING

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1 – Listen to a short interview with an anthropologist discussing the science of friendship. Pay attention to how the speaker explains why friendship is important and how friendship compares to romantic or parental love.

Love and Friendship

1 - According to the anthropologist, why do we tend to underestimate friendship compared to other kinds of love?

- a) Because friendship doesn't last long.
- b) Because friendship is new in modern life.
- c) Because society often places romantic and parental love above it.

2 - What does the research say about what happens in our brains when we interact with friends?

- a) Our brain processes friendship as a form of love.
- b) There is no chemical reaction.
- c) Friendship causes our brain to shut down social reward pathways.

3 - In the interview, what example does the anthropologist use to illustrate cultural differences in expressing love for friends?

- a) Comparing British people vs Mediterranean or South Americans.
- b) Comparing northern and southern hemispheres.
- c) Comparing urban vs rural people.

4 - According to a study at Oxford cited by the anthropologist, women tend to be more emotionally intimate with whom?

5 - What do men often find friendship gives them, the anthropologist says?

- a) Romantic fulfilment.
- b) Competition and motivation.
- c) Relaxation and a place where they can truly be themselves.

6 - The anthropologist suggests that for many single people today, friendship might act as:

- a) A way to avoid commitment.
- b) A substitute for a romantic partner — offering support, love, and belonging.
- c) A distraction from loneliness without deep importance.

7 - The speaker argues that love should be considered a fundamental need just like:

8 - The anthropologist says that love is not simply an emotion because:

- a) Love is only for romantic relationships.
- b) Emotions are always short-lived.
- c) Love includes many components — passion, affection, fear, need, motivation.

Full Name _____

READING COMPREHENSION

The science of why friendships keep us healthy

Humans have long recognised the value of friendships — but now science is confirming just how essential they are. Stable, healthy friendships have been linked to better mental and physical health, greater resilience, and even longer life.

Neuroscience shows that social interaction activates the brain's reward system. Chemicals such as oxytocin, dopamine and other neuromodulators are released when we connect with friends — creating feelings of pleasure, trust, and safety.

More than simple companionship, friendships serve as vital support networks. People with close friends report less loneliness and fewer stress-related problems. They often have stronger social support, which helps during difficult times.

Interestingly, sharing experiences and emotions with friends — even without talking — can improve our mood. Studies show that when friends share an emotional event together, their brain's reward circuitry becomes active, and they feel better than if alone.

Because of all these benefits, many psychologists argue that social connection — especially friendship — should be seen as a basic human need, comparable to food, water or safety.

In short: friendship is not just a pleasant extra — it's essential. It supports our well-being, fuels our brain's reward systems, and helps us cope with life's challenges.

Retrieved from: <https://www.apa.org/monitor/2023/06/cover-story-science-friendship>

Comprehension Questions

1. According to the adapted article, what are some of the health benefits associated with stable, healthy friendships?

2. Which brain chemicals are mentioned as being released during interactions with friends, producing feelings of pleasure and trust?

3. What surprising finding is mentioned about sharing emotional experiences with friends?

4. The article suggests that friendship might be considered a basic human need comparable to what?

5. Do you feel that friendships in your life give you the benefits described in the article (support, pleasure, safety)? How and why?